

The Bachchans

PREMIER PARIVAR

Despite several knocks to their professional and personal status, the Bachchans, with the addition of India's best known beauty, remained Bollywood's premier parivar. Everything the triple 'A's did, made headlines. Their wedding divided Bollywood, their tax queries excited Parliament, and an award to Amitabh nearly derailed a national ceremony. Their favourite political party was ousted in Uttar Pradesh, their chit fund friend was no longer their *sahara* and a much touted remake of one of India's greatest films fell flat on its face, but brand Bachchan survived to fight another day. The wedding of the year became our greatest blood sport while guessing the arrival of Junior Bachchan's junior became the pet parlour game. Whether visiting temples or breaking karva chauth *vrats*, being disinvited to film festivals or hauled up and then cleared for owning farm land, they became a hungry media's newest obsession. Also perhaps its most powerful victims. Count them out? No way. Expect all three of them to re-establish their claim to being the *sarkar* of Bollywood next year. **by Kaveree Bamzai**



AP PHOTO

WHETHER visiting temples or breaking karva chauth *vrats* or being hauled up for owning farm land, the Bachchans became media's newest obsession

Shah Rukh Khan

KHAN'T STOP HIM

He started the year as a wannabe Bachchan and ended it with everyone wanting to be him. Two of the year's biggest hits, a respectable showing on *Kaun Banega Crorepati 3*, and a growing friendship with the first family of Indian politics made Shah Rukh Khan Bollywood's biggest superstar of 2007. Whether it was growing a six-pack overnight, romancing a woman half his age or becoming a metaphor for sporting victories, Shah Rukh showed he was

first among equals. In controversy and celebration, at cricket matches or in star spats, there was no escaping him. Whether it was laughing at his own oeuvre in *Om Shanti Om* or standing against discrimination of Muslims in *Chak De! India*, he showed both his head and heart were in the right place. Not bad for someone who has spent almost two decades at the top of what is an unceasingly unreal world. **by Kaveree Bamzai**

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IMAGE FORUM